

Battle of equals: Pace firepower, fragile spin play and middle-overs anchors frame New Zealand's Group D encounter with South Africa in Ahmedabad. M. VEDHAN



>> England vs West Indies, Mumbai

The two teams are familiar foes, having faced off eight times since the last T20 World Cup. England has had the upper hand, winning six of those contests, while two-time champion West Indies, a pale shadow of its vibrant T20I team of the last decade, has struggled since hosting the last showpiece in 2024. A track record of 13 wins and 25 defeats in 40 matches points towards a precipitous slump in need of urgent attention.

Against this gloomy backdrop, the Men in Maroon will seek inspiration from their last T20 World Cup campaign in India, when Carlos Brathwaite's four consecutive sixes off Ben Stokes in the final over earned them their second title. Both teams have had contrasting journeys since, with England becoming a pacesetter of high-intent batting even as the Windies have lagged, with their power-hitters prioritising franchise cricket. An undercooked English bowling department, on a flat Wankhede pitch, could provide the ideal release for the West Indies batting unit, led by Shai Hope at the top and consolidated through the middle by Rovman Powell. But they should expect England to fight fire with fire when Phil Salt and Jos Buttler are unleashed.



Divergent paths: England meets West Indies at Wankhede in a clash of contrasting trajectories, with firepower, flat conditions and an undercooked bowling attack framing the contest. REUTERS

>> New Zealand vs South Africa, Ahmedabad

The contest between New Zealand and South Africa will be a rare battle of equals in the group stage, with two teams moulded very similarly facing off in Ahmedabad. New Zealand's world-class pacers, Jacob Duffy, Matt Henry and Lockie Ferguson, will meet their match in Marco Jansen, Kagiso Rabada and Anrich Nortje. They will be supplemented by able tweakers on either side, with Mitchell Santner and Keshav Maharaj in the mix. Both teams also recently toured India and betrayed their weakness against quality spin bowling in subcontinental conditions in their respective T20I series defeats. Their batting philosophies, too, are not dissimilar, having not yet quite embraced the high-tempo methods adopted by India, Australia and England. Both teams have not done away with anchors in the shortest format, with Daryl Mitchell and Aiden Markram tasked with middle-overs consolidation before a late-overs surge. With similar line-ups, personnel and tactics facing off, it will be interesting to see which team comes out on top.